

Orca

Orcinus orca

The orca, or killer whale, is not a true whale but the largest member of the dolphin family. Living up to 90 years, it is the only cetacean that regularly eats other marine mammals, including other dolphins.

Intelligent hunters

There are three types of killer whales: resident, transient, and offshore; each group has a different diet and lives in different areas. Resident orcas form the largest groups, or pods, and primarily hunt fish, squid, and octopuses. Transient orcas are the world’s biggest predators of warm-blooded animals, feeding almost exclusively on marine mammals, including large whales, as well as seabirds such as penguins. The offshore orcas eat fish, especially sharks.

All types of orca are highly intelligent. Adults teach juveniles how to hunt: herding, stunning prey with tail strikes, and “wave-washing” seals off sea ice.

Orca pods range from just a few to 50 or more. An average pod generally includes smaller groups comprising a mature female and its female offspring. They communicate using a shared vocabulary of clicks, whistles, and pulsed calls (which sound like screams to human ears). Different populations have distinctive calls.

Orcas mate throughout the year, but most often in late spring and summer. After a 15- to 18-month gestation period—the longest of all cetaceans—females bear a single calf, usually born tail-first.

◀ SURFACE BREACH

Breaching, tail and flipper slaps, and “spy-hopping”—pushing only the head above water—are known forms of communication among orcas.

- ↔ 25–33 ft (7.5–10 m)
- 🏠 Up to 7.3 tons (6.6 metric tons)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🐟 Fish, mammals, seabirds
- 🌐



Worldwide

King eider

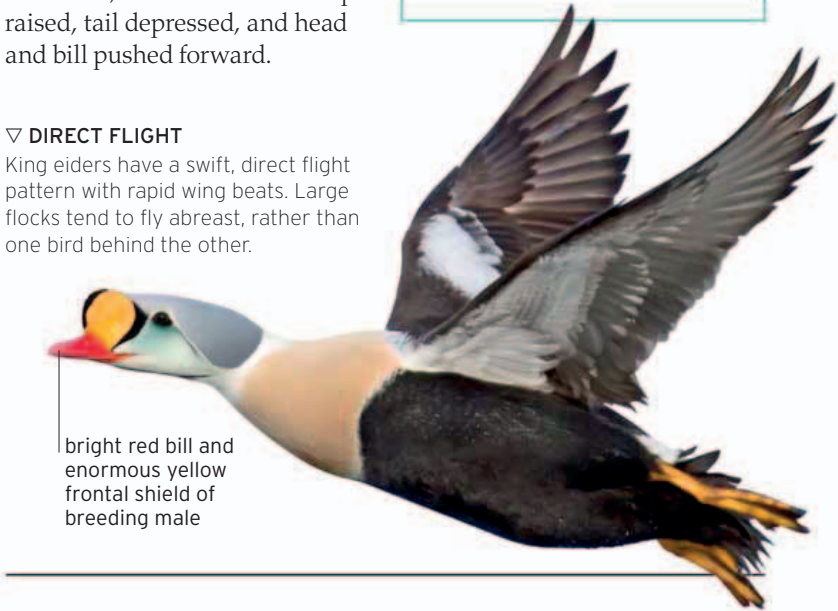
Somateria spectabilis

This sea-going duck winters mostly north of the Arctic Circle and breeds on small lakes or rivers in coastal tundra and bogs. The king eider dives as deep as 115 ft (35 m) for food, but also tips forward to forage in the shallows. Courtship displays are ritualized, with the male’s rump raised, tail depressed, and head and bill pushed forward.

- ↔ 19–25 in (48–63 cm)
- 🏠 3–5 lb (1.4–2 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Mollusks, crabs
- 🌐

▽ DIRECT FLIGHT

King eiders have a swift, direct flight pattern with rapid wing beats. Large flocks tend to fly abreast, rather than one bird behind the other.



Atlantic salmon

Salmo salar

Young Atlantic salmon spend a year, or more, in the upper reaches of clear-running rivers before swimming out to sea. Once at sea, the salmon follows coastal currents in search of food, and matures rapidly. After three or four years at sea, it locates its birth river by the unique smell of its water and journeys back to breed.



- ↔ 3–5 ft (0.9–1.5 m)
- 🏠 5–20 lb (2.3–9.1 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Insect larvae; fish
- 🌐

◀ HEADING UPSTREAM

Many salmon die on the tough journey upstream, but survivors may make the trip three or four times.